COPING STRATEGIES FOR PARENTS

Parenting young children can be incredibly demanding and exhausting.

Here are a variety of coping skills that may help you stay calm during challenging moments. Some skills will likely work better for you than others.

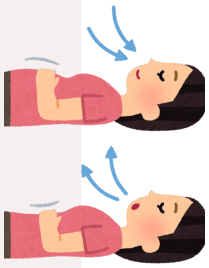
By trying out a variety of skills in different scenarios, you can create your own 'toolbox' of strategies to help you through difficult situations.

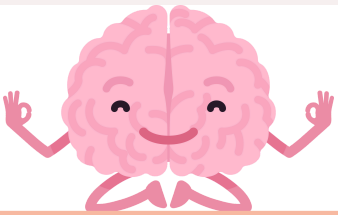
DEEP BREATHING

Taking long, slow breaths helps your brain and body calm down:

- Be sure to breathe into your belly, rather than your chest. Putting a hand on your belly can help.
- Breathe out longer than you breathe in for maximum benefit
- Counting can help as well. Try breathing in on a count of four, pause briefly, and then breathe out on a count of eight.
- Breathe for at least 2-3 minutes to feel the calming effect

There are many YouTube videos and apps that provide guidance for deep breathing. Here are a few examples:





Headspace – Mini Meditation – Breathe (Headspace) https://youtu.be/cEqZthCaMpo

Belly breathing exercise: Calming the body and mind (Indiana University School of Medicine) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7Ep5mKuRmAA

How to do Deep Breathing (TherapistAid) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EYQsRBNYdPk

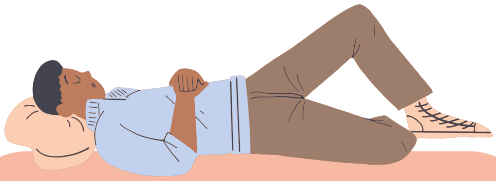
COPING STRATEGIES FOR PARENTS

PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELAXATION

Tensing and releasing our muscles can help let go of stored up stress:

- Squeeze one muscle group at a time (e.g., shoulders, arms, core, legs, jaw) for 5-10 seconds and release
- Squeeze your muscles enough to feel the tension, but not to the point that it hurts
- Notice how your muscles feel when you are squeezing them and how they feel when you relax them

Many YouTube videos walk you through how to do this, including:



Progressive Muscle Relaxation – Bridge the gAPP (Eastern Health NL)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GZ9PHsbt-m4

5 SENSES GROUNDING

Focusing on our five senses and our environment around us can shift our focus from intense emotions and thoughts. With your child, walk through these steps to bring them back to the present moment:



- Notice 5 things you can see (chair, table, lamp, etc.)
- Notice 4 things you can touch (shirt, chair, your hair, etc.)
- Notice 3 things you can hear (fan, people talking, car, etc.)
- Notice 2 things you can smell (lotion, shirt, etc.)
- Notice 1 thing you can taste (snack, water, pretend to “taste the air,” etc.)



COPING STRATEGIES FOR PARENTS

POSITIVE COPING THOUGHTS

Our internal voice can be either positive or negative. The way that we think about challenging situations can affect how we feel and what we do.

- Identifying helpful thoughts in advance can help with getting through tough moments
- Making reminders for yourself (phone alerts, sticky note) can help make coping thoughts into a habit

Examples of coping thoughts:

This is an opportunity for me to practice coping with hard feelings

I can feel anxious and still handle the situation

This feeling is uncomfortable. It will be over soon and I will be ok

I am strong enough to deal with this

Mistakes are a normal part of life

5 SENSES SOOTHING

Flooding our senses with positive and/or intense sensations can help us cope with challenging emotions and thoughts. Here are a few ideas:



- Touch: soft blanket/clothing, hug, warm or cold shower/hot or cold pack
- Listen to: music, nature sounds, hum a song
- Look at: soothing video (waterfall, campfire), favorite photos, through your window
- Smell: essential oil, coffee/tea, fresh outdoor air
- Taste: mint, tea/coffee, sour food/candy



ADAPTED FROM THE MOM POWER VIRTUAL GROUP CURRICULUM (MUZIK & ROSENBLUM ET AL., UNPUBLISHED MANUAL, 2021)

COPING STRATEGIES FOR PARENTS



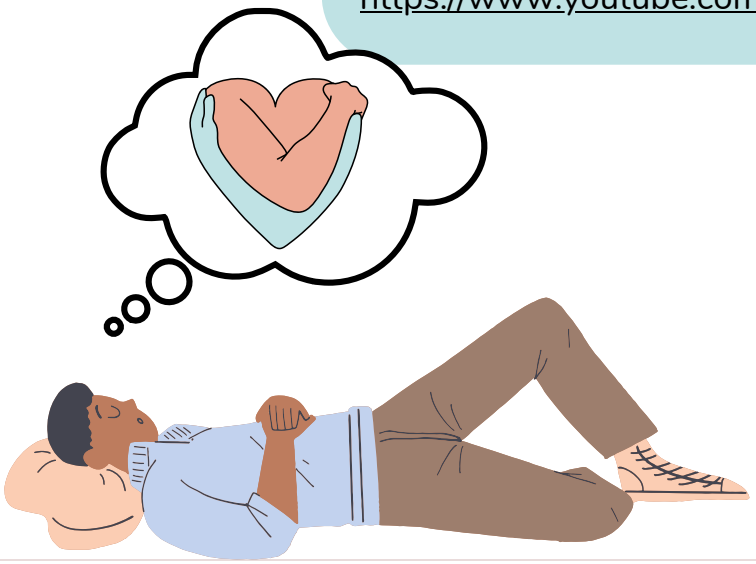
CONTAINING CHALLENGING FEELINGS

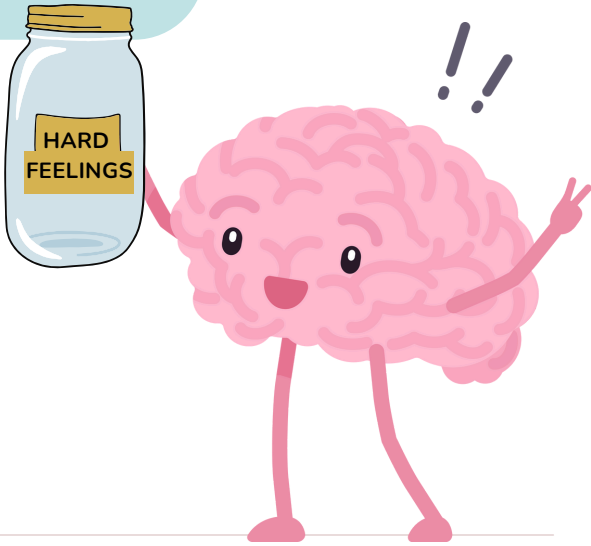
- Sometimes we experience thoughts and feelings about past challenging experiences at times when we don't have the bandwidth to think about or process them.
- This visualization exercise can help you practice 'containing' the emotions until you are at a time and place when you are ready to deal with them.

Example:

- Containment: A Practice for Soothing the Nervous System and Coming to Present (The Trauma-Conscious Yoga Method)

Mountains Meditation – Narrated by Sir David Attenborough (Digitalnauts): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZIJ5KovxnV4





COPING STRATEGIES FOR PARENTS

Self-Compassion

We often internally talk to ourselves much more harshly than how we would talk to a close friend. Developing a more self-compassionate internal voice can help us through challenging experiences. Below are examples of exercises and videos that practice self-compassion:

Self-Compassion Exercises by Dr. Kristin Neff Mountain Meditation: Grounding in Times of Uncertainty (OpenUp) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vm1EPEZ9T88



Meditation with Visualization:

Using visualization strategies through guided meditation can help us feel more grounded and calmer. Here are two examples of mountain-themed meditation:

Mountain Meditation: Grounding in Times of Uncertainty (OpenUp) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vm1EPEZ9T88

Mountains Meditation – Narrated by Sir David Attenborough (Digitalnauts): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZIJ5KovxnV4